JULIEFITZIMMONSEDIT

Travel Radio Australia and we've caught up with Julie Fitzsimmons from Lodestar. She's the chair of Department for Business and Trade. We're here in Khan at the Mapik conference and Julie, welcome to the program.

Thank you very much. I'm very glad to be talking to you. Welcome to Khan.

Thank you very much and Julie, tell us first of all about Lodestar. It's L-O-D-E-S-T-A-R. What organization is that and what's it all about? Lodestar is a guiding light which is always helpful when you're traveling and we are here to help organizations develop a strategy and turn thought into action.

How do you go and do that? And we work with all sorts of organizations, particularly to this environment, those in the experience world, those who are developing experiences, creating those experiences and we help them grow their businesses internationally and nationally. Now this conference is full of those kind of people. It's really the place to be looking for these kind of connections.

What's your experience been like here? Well I always enjoy Mapik. I've been here in Khan coming for 23 years to this event. It's certainly maybe not as large as it used to be because we don't have as much development but it's very active.

There's lots of people here who are interested in taking projects into other territories and I think that's what's really interesting, having those conversations, making those connections and making those projects happen. And what's your background Julie? Where did you come from to be in this space? Oh my word. Now there's a question.

My background, my consultancies, we've been around for 30 years so we've been developing work in this area for a long time but it came from development project that we were doing with the International Council of Shopping Centers 23 years ago and we had to go out, American organization, go out and help them grow internationally and we came to Mapik and we went to the other big fairs and we just got embedded in this sector. So that's really how we got into this sector and increasingly this event has been less about retail and more about experience. That could be experiential retail but also it can be all sorts of other sorts of experiences too.

Now speaking of that, you're on the board of Experience UK. Can you tell us about that? Experience UK came from our business department, the Department of Business and Trade, as a promotional vehicle internationally for what UK has to offer in the experience economy. It's developed into a trade association and is the fast, is a very fast-growing organization now and works with those who create experiences, those who operate them and those who have the places where they go.

It's particularly important in the UK at the moment because we have some big projects coming into the UK internationally so if you take the Universal Project which is developing a brand new theme park in the UK in Bedford, that's bringing in, you know, it's going to employ 20,000 people, it's going to bring millions of tourists into that area and it's very important that we get that project right and so we're very involved in supporting that. Yes and tell us about some of the other big projects that are on the table now for Experience UK. Yes I mean London's seeing all sorts of projects.

I mean if you if you are you know coming to London you'll see projects which are competitive social. It's almost like an elevated pub isn't it, competitive social. You know you've got elevated pub games and those kind of things and it's creating an environment where people are getting outside of their home.

You know so what we're seeing is a lot more of that kind of project but we're seeing other projects like the new big project called Wake the Tiger which is at Westfield. It's a big project about 80,000 square foot. I'm not sure if you're in meters.

If it's meters that's 8,000 square meters. It's a big project that's all about the planet. You know it's very much about the planet and it's a big big project, big experiential project.

We're seeing projects like the Traitors in London which is all about the television program, all about you know the Faithfuls and the Unfaithfuls I suppose. The Traitors and that's been a really successful project and they're taking that project from the UK internationally. So we're seeing in the UK, we've got other big projects that are happening in the UK, Freight Island in Manchester and Newcastle and Soon Interleads.

That project is very much about music and about creating new music venues as we see that as a very important part of our development. Camden, Camden is a very important part of any visitor's experience coming into London and what we're seeing there is the old markets and the old piece but we're seeing some regeneration in that area to really upscale some of it. Not losing what it has but upscaling some of it and also Camden Film Quarter which is a very interesting thing which are starting to elevate the experience that you have when you come to the UK.

Because London in particular it's probably the UK's number one if not in the world top five destinations for the world's visitors and we've had some recent things like the pedestrianization of Oxford Street which had a few teething problems I think but they're sorting that all out and that looks like it's going to be good. You know these projects always have a problem don't they? They have problems at the start and they work out the things that go wrong and the things that they fix those things it's long overdue. I mean Oxford Street has been an embarrassment almost and yet a wonderful place so it's needed that real upgrade and that pedestrianization is you know a really massive signal that they mean business that they are actually going to tidy this up and make it the exciting street it should be.

People want to be there they want to lease it and they also want to go there and shop there and also what they did was they've developed the ends of it they haven't just developed the middle so they've developed the Tottenham Court Road End they're now developing the Marble Arch End so they're not just looking at a piece in the middle they're very much taking a whole estate approach to that so it's really quite exciting that for London. The good thing about the UK is once you're in London or Leeds or Birmingham it's so easy to get around these places isn't it? I find that quite funny because it really is easy it's not a very big country and it's very well connected and we make such a thing oh well it's not London you know go all the way to Liverpool might take you three hours on the train oh my god what is that in two hours to Manchester it's just it's nowhere I think if you were in Australia you'd be laughing at that certainly in the US they laugh at that they think we're silly when we talk about distance it's very easy to get around and there's some great project there's a new project being announced for Beatles big Beatles Museum that's going into Liverpool how exciting is that and so you know we have got projects as well which are not just London there's lots of really interesting things in other parts of the UK now I can tell you're a northern girl by your accent tell us about a few of the things that are happening around your neck of the woods ah the north I'm actually from Cumbria which is way up on the border and what we're seeing there is that we're seeing tourism around our heritage and also our environment it's beautiful so what you're seeing our projects with light goate you know which is really about an active climbing abseiling was it wiring all of that sort of thing which is very active so we're seeing that in those sort of much more it isn't really about saying okay go and climb that hill it is about having some active things to do when you're there as well which then yes you may also go and do that or go and swim that lake you know that's always very exciting there's a lot of sport led regeneration that we're seeing so if you're into the Geordie accent and you want to go to Newcastle you can you can there's a lot of sport led regeneration there for women and you know for girls and girls and boys men and women and we're seeing a lot of more sport led regeneration which is also creating new facilities which then can be used for community use too so really interesting things happening there it's a very exciting environment I think at the moment in the UK we've got a new Prime Minister obviously Andy Burnham and who is from the north and he's creating a Downing Street of them of the you know a number 10 rather of the north in Manchester which means there's much more emphasis on those different locations in the north so I think that's a very exciting thing you can go onto the west side go to Leeds and you're seeing new projects happening there as well it's just a very dynamic environment I think the UK at the moment before we go give us another little overview of lodestar which is your project and and how does that work and what is it involved well really our organization is here to help people to support people grow and the other thing we try and do is develop thought leadership so we're very interested in where are things going and we have some great operators here are Zeppelin X over here I was talking to them they want to come to the UK it's all sorts of people here who are interested but how do you unlock that how do you unlock that and help people do that and so we're here really to help people to help people make projects happen this is what we do Julie Fitzsimmons can you tell us the websites that people should go to to find out more yes indeed so

lodestar website is lodestaruk.com L O D E S T A R U K dot com and experience UK is experience UK dot org thanks so much Julie for being part of the program and it's great that we can say hello from you from from Cumbria to all of our English speaking people in Australia oh thank you very much we love the Australians you know